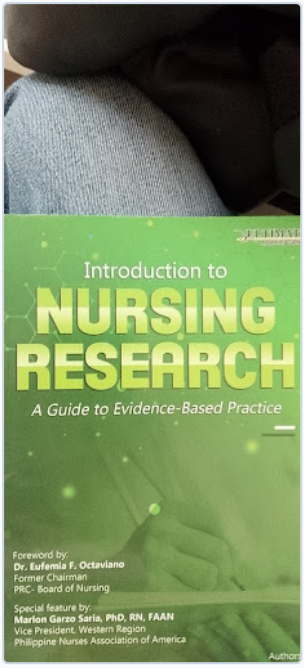
COURSE LEARNING MATERIAL & MODULE

NCM115: Nursing Research

Chapter 4: The Research Process – Conceptual Phase & Literature Review

Course Code: Nursing Research NCM115
Research Instructor: RENE S. REAL, RN
Academic Program: Bachelor of Science in Nursing (BSN)
Institution: Saint Ferdinand College - College of Nursing

PRIMARY REFERENCE SOURCE & TEXTBOOK CITATION



Introduction to Nursing Research: A Guide to Evidence-Based Practice

Core Reference Material for NCM115

- **Foreword by:** Dr. Eufemia F. Octaviano (Former Chairman, PRC - Board of Nursing)
- **Special Feature by:** Marlon Garzo Saria, PhD, RN, FAAN (Vice President, Western Region - Philippine Nurses Association of America)
- **Publisher:** Ultimate Learning Series

MODULE LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Upon completing this self-paced learning module in **Nursing Research NCM115**, nursing students at Saint Ferdinand College are expected to:

1. Demonstrate an understanding of the purposes and importance of conducting a Literature Review in nursing research.
2. Differentiate between Conceptual vs. Research Literature, and Primary vs. Secondary evidence sources.
3. Apply systematic methods (Coding, Protocols, Matrices) in locating, abstracting, and evaluating empirical studies.
4. Formulate research title structures and conceptual frameworks compliant with Evidence-Based Practice standards.

CHAPTER 4: THE RESEARCH PROCESS – CONCEPTUAL PHASE

Course Study Guide & Intensive Module: Review of Related Literature (RRL)

Course: Nursing Research NCM115
Research Instructor: RENE S. REAL, RN
Focus Area: Literature Review, Matrices & Frameworks
Target Level: BSN Level III Nursing Students

1. INTRODUCTION TO REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE (RRL)

> *"The review of related literature is a written summary of existing knowledge based on a research problem obtained from an in-depth search on non-research and research references. It includes a statement indicating what the present study will add to what is already known, serving as a written, analytic summary of research findings on a topic of interest and providing essential context."*

A rigorous literature review establishes the scientific grounding of nursing research. It synthesizes existing empirical data and conceptual models to provide a rationale for new inquiries, ensuring that clinical interventions and practices are backed by validated evidence.

2. PURPOSES AND IMPORTANCE OF LITERATURE REVIEW

Conducting a comprehensive literature review serves six foundational research objectives:

1. **Problem Identification & Refinement:** Helps or guides the researcher in searching for or selecting a better research problem or topic.
2. **Enhancing Understanding:** Helps the investigator understand his topic thoroughly for better, more rigorous research execution.
3. **Preventing Duplication:** Ensures that there will be no unintentional duplication of existing published studies.
4. **Locating Resources:** Helps and guides the researcher in locating more sources of related clinical and theoretical information.
5. **Designing Research Methodology:** Helps and guides the researcher in selecting appropriate research design, sampling, and instrumentation.
6. **Comparative Findings Analysis:** Helps and guides the researcher in making comparisons between his findings with the findings of other researchers.

3. CATEGORIZATION: TYPES OF LITERATURE

1. Conceptual Literature (Related Literature)

Composed of discussions of facts, concepts, theories, and principles to which the present study is related. These non-empirical materials are found in books, encyclopedias, professional journals, magazines, and publications. They provide theoretical scaffolding.

2. Research Literature (Related Studies)

Consists of empirical studies, inquiries, or investigations already conducted to which the proposed study is related or has direct bearing. Typically includes unpublished materials like manuscripts, theses, and dissertations based on direct data collection.

4. ESSENTIAL GUIDELINES FOR WRITING RESEARCH TITLES

5. VISUAL ARCHITECTURE OF RESEARCH LITERATURE (FIGURE 4.4)

Literature sources are categorized systematically into empirical and non-empirical streams based on authorship and data origin:



6. SOURCES OF LITERATURE: PRIMARY VS. SECONDARY DISTINCTION

Primary Sources (Preferred)

Direct descriptions of empirical studies written by the original researchers who conducted them. Ideal for nursing research due to first-hand methodological accuracy.

- Original research articles in peer-reviewed journals
- Dissertations, theses, and grant reports
- Oral research presentations at clinical symposia

Secondary Sources

Descriptions or syntheses of studies prepared by someone other than the original investigator. Excellent for acquiring quick overviews and identifying primary references.

- Literature review articles and meta-analyses
- Textbook summaries and systematic reviews
- Critiques and reaction papers by clinical experts

7. COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF LITERATURE CLASSIFICATION

Dimension	Primary Empirical Sources	Secondary Empirical Sources	Conceptual Literature
Author Origin	Original Investigator(s)	Third-party Reviewer / Editor	Theorist / Domain Expert
Data Type	Direct First-hand Data	Summarized / Aggregated Data	Concepts, Theories & Opinions
Clinical Value	High Evidence Rigor	Broad Overview & Citations	Theoretical Frameworking
Nursing Examples	RCT on wound care protocols	Meta-analysis on pressure ulcers	Orem's Self-Care Nursing Model

8. MAJOR STEPS IN CONDUCTING A LITERATURE REVIEW (FIGURE 4.5)

Execution of a systematic RRL requires structured progression through four core phases:



9. STEP-BY-STEP RRL EXECUTION METHODOLOGY

STEP 1: Locating Relevant Literature

Researchers utilize four primary strategies to uncover relevant clinical and theoretical evidence:

- **Bibliographic Databases:** Searching indexed electronic databases (e.g., CINAHL, PubMed, MEDLINE) using targeted keywords and Boolean operators.
- **Ancestry Approach:** Tracking references cited in relevant studies back to their original source ("footnote chasing").
- **Descendancy Approach:** Searching forward in time for recent studies that have cited pivotal earlier source publications.
- **Grey Literature:** Sourcing unpublished technical reports, conference proceedings, government documents, and dissertations to avoid publication bias.

STEP 2: Abstracting and Recording Information

Systematic recording requires standardizing key study data to facilitate cross-study comparison:

1. **Coding Systems:** Developing intricate coding protocols to organize quantitative/qualitative data for software analysis.
2. **Protocols:** Creating standardized forms to extract citations, theoretical frames, methods, sample sizes, and key findings systematically.
3. **Matrices:** Utilizing structured grid tables to directly support thematic synthesis across studies.

10. TAXONOMY OF LITERATURE REVIEW MATRICES

Matrix Type	Core Analytical Question Addressed	Primary Data Extracted & Purpose
Methodologic Matrix	*"How have researchers studied this research question?"*	Focuses on study designs, sampling methods, instruments, measurement tools, and statistical procedures.
Result Matrix	*"What have the researchers found across studies?"*	Organizes empirical findings, statistical significance, effect sizes, and clinical outcomes across publications.
Evaluation Matrix	*"How much confidence do we have in the evidence?"*	Evaluates methodological quality, risk of bias, threats to internal/external validity, and study limitations.

11. STEP 3 & STEP 4: EVALUATION AND WRITTEN SYNTHESIS

STEP 3: Critiquing and Evaluating the Evidence

Critiquing requires rigorous evaluation of six mandatory structural components of retrieved studies:

- **Study Purpose:** Clarity of research objective and hypothesis.
- **Sample Size & Selection:** Sampling technique, power, and representation.
- **Research Design:** Internal validity and control of confounding variables.
- **Data Collection Procedures:** Tool reliability and validity.
- **Data Analysis:** Appropriateness of statistical tests used.
- **Conclusions:** Justification of inferences based on data.

STEP 4: Preparing a Written Literature Review

A high-quality literature review must comply with four structural guidelines:

- **Synthesized Evidence:** Must present a well-organized synthesis of current state evidence rather than an unintegrated series of summaries.
- **Avoid Stringing Quotes:** Should neither be a string of direct quotes nor a repetitive sequence of abstracts.
- **Paraphrased Tone:** Must be entirely summarized in the researcher's own academic phrasing with appropriate citations.
- **Critical Synthesis:** Recap key findings clearly while explicitly stating how credible and generalizable they are.

12. CLINICAL FIELDWORK & FRAMEWORK DEVELOPMENT

Undertaking Clinical Fieldwork in Research

Researchers embarking on clinical studies benefit significantly from spending time in clinical environments, collaborating with nursing clinicians, observing live practices, and discussing challenges. Clinical fieldwork provides key context regarding current clinical trends, diagnostic procedures, care delivery models, and patient perspectives—ensuring the research is grounded in real-world practice.

13. THEORETICAL VS. CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORKS

Quantitative and qualitative nursing studies rely on theoretical underpinnings to structure hypotheses and variable interactions:

Attribute	Theoretical Framework	Conceptual Framework
Definition	Based on an existing, formal theory (e.g., Roy's Adaptation Model, Orem's Self-Care Theory).	Roots in specific concepts and operational links constructed by the researcher for a specific study.
Scope & Origin	Broad, systemic view explaining relationships among abstract concepts across contexts.	Narrower, tailored rationale formulated when no single formal theory covers the research question.
Primary Role	Tests or applies established theoretical propositions to clinical nursing problems.	Maps out variables, interrelationships, and operational constructs specific to the current study.

14. CHARACTERISTICS OF NURSING RESEARCH THEORIES

A robust theory in nursing research exhibits four defining characteristics:

1. **Systematic View:** Consists of interrelated constructs, definitions, and propositions that systematically view nursing phenomena.